

Racing Against the Storm

A flash of lightning. A dead tree. A bolt thunders down onto a mighty oak, rendering it mutilated. Instantly. Billowing clouds blanket the skies, concealing the world from any of the original scarce beams of sunlight that once illuminated the world. Pounding rain aggressively lashes against oversaturated dirt, leaving the thicket floor completely flooded. The howling wind whips against the trees, threatening to violently uproot any unsuspecting sustenance. The surviving golden brown leaves, caught in the storm's wrath, whirl around in a despairing dance of survival.

Clashing against the overwhelming rain and near sub-zero temperature, an unfortunate clump of lanky high school adolescents treks through the thickets of the mountain foothills. Hovering about the thickets, a thick fog obscures all. Clinging onto their meager supply of vision, the cross country teams blindly scurries through.

Buried in the cross country horde, Alex battles to maintain his pace. Three others pass him. Panting, Alex murmurs, "they won't last long!" Heart pounding. Muscles aching. A sudden jolt of pain in his chest. Disregarding the pain and heaviness in his legs, Alex ceaselessly persists, barely clinging on to runner #36, who barely managed to elude Alex's dash. Through the very edge of his peripheral vision and the impenetrable fog that overwhelms the entire forest, Alex senses the faint outline of five people: his mother, father, younger sisters, and cross country coach. With a sudden rush of adrenaline, Alex darts forward, outpacing the runner that persistently eluded him for the past three miles. His dampened trotting transforms into perfect strides, resisting the slippery boggy floor. Rock fragments lay scattered on the steep mountain incline, displaying a conglomerate of mixed sedimentary rocks.

Menacing brambles everywhere. Struggling to avoid the sharp rocks that blanket the narrowing path, a sharp pain stings his right leg. A trickle of blood. Ignoring the loose thorn that lodged itself into his calf, Alex conquers the final set of rocks and battles against the violent wind, nearly reaching the mountain's summit. Summoning his last reserve of energy, Alex sprints to the summit, and notices the checkered flag with a bright neon red "FINISH LINE" written, waving proudly in the storm. With gratitude, Alex sprints to the finish line and instantly collapses on the murky dirt passing the finish line. The storm was fierce, but it couldn't extinguish Alex's flaming pride. Although Alex wasn't able to obtain the delicate, golden medal, he gained something more valuable—a sense of resilience.